DIGITALKART · 2027 INTAKE EDITION

The Study in Canada Playbook 2027

Study permits, post-graduation work permits and permanent residence, for Indian students who would rather not guess

59%
refusal rate on new study permit applications, 2025

CAD 23,448
living costs you must prove, from 1 September 2026

17 chapters · 6 printable worksheets · every figure sourced and dated

Rules verified against IRCC, the Canada Gazette, Statistics Canada, the Federal Court and the provinces on 10 November 2026

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The book on two pages

If you read nothing else, read this. It is the whole argument, in the order the decisions happen, with the number that makes each one urgent.

1. The permit is a documentary exam, not a lottery. IRCC's own figure: a 59% refusal rate on new study permit applications in 2025, against 52% in 2024. Indian approval rates were 30% for 2025 and 41% for January to April 2026.
2. Choose the credential before the institution. A master's at a public institution needs no attestation letter from 1 January 2026, earns a three-year work permit from 8 months of study, and keeps your spouse eligible for an open work permit. A postgraduate diploma does none of those three things.
3. The attestation letter is a quota token, not a formality. It must be valid on the day you submit, it expires on 31 December if undated, and it cannot be reused once a decision is made. Confirm your institution can issue one in your cap year before you pay a deposit.
4. The 2027 cap is unpublished as of 10 November 2026. The 2027-2029 Levels Plan sets 150,000 student arrivals a year inside 370,000 temporary resident arrivals. Plan on 2026-style rules, and get every institutional commitment in writing.
5. Money must be real, aged and explained. CAD 23,448 living costs for a single applicant from 1 September 2026, plus tuition, plus travel. Six months of statements, source of every large credit, sponsor documents that match IRCC's published list. Financial evidence was the leading ground in 47% of refusal letters studied.
6. The decisive test is whether you will leave. It contributed to over 90% of Indian refusals. Evidence beats assertion: property, a named job waiting, a business with provable turnover, a career plan that names Indian employers and salary bands.
7. Never let an agent create a document. Misrepresentation under section 40 of the IRPA carries five years of inadmissibility, and it attaches to you.
8. Do the medical exam before you apply, with a panel physician. India requires it for stays over six months. It is valid 12 months and must still be valid when you land.
9. Expect eight weeks from India, and add four. Doctoral applicants and their families are processed within 14 days. The service standard is 60 days outside Canada, met 86% of the time.
10. After graduation you pass three gates: general eligibility, program-based requirements (CLB 7 for degrees, CLB 5 for college; field of study for non-degree programs), and location. Apply within 180 days of completion.
11. Permanent residence is arithmetic, not hope. Canadian Experience Class cut-offs ran 507 to 523 in 2026; French-language rounds ran 382 to 435. French and occupation choice move a score more than another qualification.
12. If refused, order the officer's notes before you do anything else. Then fix the specific ground. Judicial review has a 15-day deadline for matters arising in Canada and 60 days outside, and the court reviews the process, not your merits.

> Every number above is sourced and dated in chapter 19. Rules change: fees on 1 December, funds on 1 September, cap allocations each November. Check before you submit.

Start Here

This playbook is for one person: an Indian student (or parent) trying to get a Canadian study permit for a 2027 intake, and trying to do it without an agent deciding what happens to your money.

Every rule in here was checked against Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC), the Canada Gazette, the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act and Regulations, Statistics Canada, the Federal Court and the provinces, on 10 November 2026. Where IRCC has not yet published something - and for 2027 it has not published the cap allocations - this book says so instead of guessing. That single habit is the difference between a file that gets approved and a file that gets refused for a detail you invented.

What you get

- The five decisions that actually determine your outcome, in the order you should make them: credential, province, institution, funds, story.
- The real numbers for 2027 applications - the CAD 23,448 living-cost floor, the CAD 150 and CAD 85 fees, the CAD 42,062 average international undergraduate tuition - with the official source named for each.
- The 2026 cap arithmetic, so you understand why a provincial attestation letter is the scarcest thing in your file and why a deposit paid too early can cost you a year.
- The refusal statistics nobody quotes in a brochure: a 59% refusal rate on new study permit applications in 2025, and financial evidence cited in 47% of refusals in a study of 1,370 refusal letters.
- Post-graduation work permit rules as they stand now: the CLB 7 and CLB 5 language gates, the field-of-study gate for non-degree programs, and the 1,107-program list frozen for 2026.
- The permanent residence arithmetic, including 2026 Express Entry cut-offs, so you can see what your plan has to look like in year four before you spend lakhs in year one.
- Six printable worksheets, including a program scorecard, a funds worksheet and a refusal diagnosis sheet.

What this is not

It is not legal advice, and it is not a promise. Immigration officers decide individual files and no book can change that. It is also not a list of "secrets" - there are none. What separates a strong file from a weak one is that every requirement is met, in the right order, with evidence that an officer can verify in under ten minutes. That is a craft, and it can be learned.

> Before you act on any number in this book, open the IRCC page named in the Sources chapter and check it. Rules changed four times in the last two years and the pace has not slowed.

1. The file that decides your next five years

Start with the number that no consultancy puts on its Instagram: IRCC told a parliamentary committee in April 2026 that the refusal rate for new study permit applications rose to 59% between January and December 2025, up from 52% in 2024. Nearly six in ten applicants who paid the fee and assembled a file were told no.

For Indian applicants the picture is sharper still. Reuters reported in November 2025, using immigration department data, that about 74% of Indian applications to study at Canadian post-secondary institutions were refused in August 2025, against about 32% in August 2023. ApplyBoard's analysis of IRCC data put the Indian approval rate at 30% for the full year 2025 and 41% for January to April 2026 - improving, but still a coin toss with a thumb on the scale.

The refusals are not random

Read the reasons and a pattern appears. In ApplyBoard's review of Indian refusals, the officer's belief that the applicant would not leave Canada contributed to more than 90% of refusals. Financial grounds appeared in roughly 33% of cases in early 2026, against about 3% in 2023 and 2024. A separate analysis of 1,370 refusal letters found inadequate proof of finances was the leading reason at 47% of refusals, with problems involving family members and expired attestation letters at 10% each.

Notice what is missing from that list: marks. Nobody is refused because their Class 12 percentage was 78 instead of 85. People are refused because the money story did not hold, or because the study plan read like a migration plan, or because a provincial attestation letter had expired before the application was submitted.

> Three things decide most Indian files: is the money real and explainable, does the program make sense for this person, and will this person leave when the permit ends. Everything else is paperwork.

What this means for how you work

Treat the application as a documentary exam with a named examiner. Every claim in your file will be matched against a document. If your study plan says you will return to a family business, the file should contain the business registration. If your uncle is funding you, the file should contain his employment letter, his relationship to you, his dependants and his bank statements, because that is exactly the list IRCC publishes for third-party sponsors.

The good news is that this is learnable and largely mechanical. The rest of this book is that mechanics, in the order you should do it: credential first, because the credential determines whether you need a provincial letter, whether your spouse can work, and how long your post-graduation work permit will be.

2. What changed, and what each change does to your plan

Canadian student immigration has been rewritten in stages since 2024. If your information comes from a YouTube video made in 2023, half of it is wrong. This is the sequence, and the consequence of each step.

Date	What changed	What it means for you
Jan 2024	Living-cost requirement for a single applicant raised from CAD 10,000 to CAD 20,635	The old advice to "show 10 lakh in the bank" stopped working two years ago
22 Jan 2024	Intake cap introduced on most study permit applications; provinces given allocations and issue attestation letters	A letter of acceptance is no longer enough; you need a provincial seat
1 Nov 2024	Post-graduation work permit rules tightened: language requirement plus a field-of-study requirement for non-degree programs	Your choice of program now decides whether you get a work permit at all
8 Nov 2024	Student Direct Stream discontinued; off-campus work limited to 24 hours a week during term	No fast lane for Indian applicants; plan for the regular stream timeline
21 Jan 2025	Open work permits for spouses restricted to master's programs of 16 months or longer, doctoral programs and listed professional degrees	A PG diploma no longer brings a working spouse
1 Sep 2025	Living-cost requirement raised to CAD 22,895	Budget rises every September; build the increase into your plan
1 Jan 2026	Master's and doctoral students at public institutions exempt from the attestation letter; K-12 and same-level extensions also exempt	The master's route became materially cheaper in time and risk
1 Sep 2026	Living-cost requirement raised to CAD 23,448 for a single applicant	This is the figure that applies to every application you file now
5 Nov 2026	2027-2029 Immigration Levels Plan published: 370,000 new temporary residents a year, including up to 150,000 international students, and 380,000 permanent resident admissions a year	Canada is not closing the door; it is holding it at a fixed width
Pending	2027 study permit cap and provincial allocations; new institutional designation framework from January 2027	Apply on the assumption that the 2027 rules will look like 2026's, and confirm before you pay a deposit

Two of those rows deserve a second look because they are widely misunderstood.

The cap is not a cap on students, it is a cap on applications

The federal cap limits how many study permit applications IRCC will accept into processing in a calendar year for applicants who need a provincial or territorial attestation letter. In 2026 that number is 309,670 applications, with a target of issuing 180,000 permits to that group. If a province's allocation is used up, further applications naming an institution in that province are returned unprocessed with the fee refunded. Returned is not refused - but from your side it looks the same: no permit, and a term you cannot start.

The 2027 numbers are not published yet, and anyone who quotes them is guessing

The 2027-2029 Levels Plan, released on 5 November 2026, sets a target of up to 150,000 new international student arrivals in each of 2027, 2028 and 2029, inside 370,000 total temporary resident arrivals a year. It does not set the 2027 application cap or the provincial allocations. IRCC's own planning documents listed "set the 2027 study permit cap in conjunction with the Immigration Levels Plan and seek Ministerial approval of provincial and territorial allocations" as a fall 2026 task. As of this writing it has not been published.

Practical consequence: if you are applying for a January or May 2027 intake, the attestation letter you hold must be issued in the 2027 cap year, and the process for that year may only be confirmed late. Ask your institution, in writing, two questions: can you issue me an attestation letter for the 2027 cap year, and when will you know your allocation. Get the answer before you wire a deposit.

3. Pick the credential before you pick the college

Most Indian applicants start with the institution - a college with a familiar name and a two-year postgraduate diploma - and then discover that the credential they chose decides three things they cared about: whether they need a provincial letter, whether their spouse can work, and whether their post-graduation work permit survives.

This is the single highest-leverage decision in the whole process, and it is made in week one, usually on the advice of whoever answers the phone at an agency.

	Master's or PhD at a public institution	Postgraduate diploma or certificate	Bachelor's degree
Provincial attestation letter	Not required from 1 Jan 2026	Required	Required
Spouse open work permit	Yes if master's is 16 months or longer; yes for PhD	No	Only for listed professional degrees such as BEng, BScN, BEd, LLB, MD
PGWP length	3 years for a master's of 8 months or more	Up to the length of the program; 3 years if 2 years or more	3 years if 4 years, otherwise up to program length
PGWP field-of-study gate	Not applicable to degree holders	Applies - your CIP code must be on the eligible list	Not applicable to degree holders
PGWP language gate	CLB 7 in all four abilities	CLB 5 in all four abilities	CLB 7 in all four abilities
Typical tuition pressure	International graduate average CAD 24,693	Program-specific, often CAD 15,000 to 20,000 a year	International undergraduate average CAD 42,062
Processing note	Doctoral applicants and their family members are processed within 14 days	Standard stream	Standard stream

Read that table twice if you are married. A two-year postgraduate diploma at a college costs less in tuition than a master's, and for a single applicant it can be a perfectly rational choice. For a couple, the diploma route means your spouse cannot get an open work permit at all - the rule since 21 January 2025 limits those permits to spouses of students in master's programs of 16 months or longer, doctoral programs, or a short list of professional degrees that includes engineering, nursing, education, law, medicine, dentistry, pharmacy, optometry and veterinary medicine.

The trap inside the diploma route

If you applied for a study permit on or after 1 November 2024 and you graduate from a college, polytechnic or other non-degree program, your post-graduation work permit depends on your program's six-digit CIP code being on IRCC's eligible field-of-study list. That list currently holds 1,107 programs, concentrated in health care and social services, education, trades, agriculture, STEM and transport. IRCC froze the list for 2026, which is helpful: what you check today is what applies all year.

The trap is that program names lie. "International Business Management" at one college may carry a CIP code that is eligible and at another a code that is not, and the officer decides on the code, not the brochure. Before you pay a deposit, ask the institution in writing for the six-digit CIP code of the exact program, then check it against IRCC's list yourself.

> If you cannot get the CIP code in writing from the institution, treat that program as ineligible until proven otherwise. A two-year diploma that produces no work permit is an expensive way to spend two years.

How to choose when both routes are open

1. If you are married and your spouse intends to work in Canada, the master's route is the only route that keeps that option - and it must be 16 months or longer.
2. If you want the longest post-study runway, a master's of 8 months or more already earns a 3-year work permit, which is the maximum available.
3. If you are single, funding-limited and targeting a licensed trade or health role, an eligible college program with a verified CIP code and a 2-year length gives you 3 years of work permit at lower tuition.
4. If you are aiming at permanent residence through Express Entry, the credential that scores points is the degree, not the diploma - check the CRS effect before you enrol, not after.

4. The attestation letter is the seat, not the letter

A provincial attestation letter (PAL), or territorial attestation letter (TAL), is a province confirming that you have been allocated one of its spaces under the federal cap. It is not a visa, not an admission, and not a promise - it is a quota token. In 2026 there are 309,670 application spaces in total, divided by province according to population.

Province or territory	2026 permits targeted (PAL-required)	2026 application spaces
Ontario	70,074	104,780
Quebec	39,474	93,069
British Columbia	24,786	32,596
Alberta	21,582	32,271
Saskatchewan	5,436	11,349
Manitoba	6,534	11,196
Nova Scotia	4,680	8,480
New Brunswick	3,726	8,004
Newfoundland and Labrador	2,358	5,507
Prince Edward Island	774	1,376
Yukon	198	257
Northwest Territories	198	785
Nunavut	180	0
Total	180,000	309,670

The gap between the two columns is the refusal rate the provinces expect: they are given more application spaces than permit targets because some applications will be refused. Quebec's numbers are larger than its population share because Quebec runs its own selection and issues its own Quebec Acceptance Certificate.

Six rules about attestation letters that decide files

1. It must be valid on the day you submit, not on the day you start classes. An application without one is not refused - it is returned unprocessed, and the processing fee is refunded.
2. A letter with no stated expiry expires on 31 December of the year it was issued, at 23:59 Eastern time. A 2026 letter cannot carry you into a 2027 intake.
3. Once a decision is made on your application - approved or refused - the letter is spent and cannot be used in a new application, unless the province is Quebec, which has its own reuse rules.
4. If you withdraw an application before a decision, you may reuse the same letter in a later application, provided it has not expired.
5. The letter must carry your full name, date of birth and address. A mismatch against your passport is a rejection waiting to happen.
6. Your institution requests it from the province, not you. That is why the question "can you issue a 2027 attestation letter" belongs in your first email to them, not your last.

Who does not need one

Since 1 January 2026, master's and doctoral students enrolled at public designated learning institutions are exempt, as are primary and secondary school students, certain Government of Canada priority groups and vulnerable cohorts, exchange students, and existing permit holders extending at the same institution and the same level of study. Participants in the Francophone Minority Communities Student Pilot are also outside the cap.

Note the precision of that exemption: public institution, graduate degree. A master's at a private institution still needs the letter, and a graduate certificate - the one-year "PG" credential sold heavily to Indian students - is not a master's degree and is not exempt.

5. Choose an institution that will still be standing in 2028

Regulations that came into force in November 2024 gave IRCC the power to penalise designated learning institutions that fail their reporting duties, with penalties running from a warning to a one-year suspension of new international admissions. During the Fall 2025 reporting cycle, IRCC reviewed 819 post-secondary institutions, found 114 suspected of non-compliance, and issued 102 formal warnings at the end of June 2026.

An institution on that list can still take your deposit. It cannot necessarily host you. If a school is suspended, any study permit application naming it is returned to the applicant unprocessed with the fee refunded - after you have paid tuition.

Provincial designation is tightening too

British Columbia replaced its Education Quality Assurance policy with a statutory regime: from 1 September 2026, every post-secondary institution in the province that advertises programs longer than six months to foreign nationals, enrols international students, or provides programs to students holding federal study permits must hold a valid designation certificate under the Post-Secondary International Education (Designated Institutions) Act. Alberta and other provinces run their own designation processes with their own conditions.

At the federal level, IRCC has said a stronger designation framework for learning institutions takes effect in January 2027. The direction of travel is one way: fewer institutions, higher reporting obligations, less tolerance for institutions that exist mainly to sell seats.

A ten-minute due-diligence routine

1. Confirm the institution is on IRCC's designated learning institution list today, and note its DLI number. The list is updated regularly; a screenshot from an agent is not evidence.
2. Confirm the specific program is PGWP-eligible, and get the six-digit CIP code in writing.
3. Search the institution's name with the words "suspension", "compliance" and "warning" alongside the current year.
4. Check the provincial regulator - for British Columbia, the designation certificate register; for Ontario, the ministry's list of approved institutions.
5. Ask for the tuition refund policy in writing, including what happens if your study permit is refused or returned unprocessed.
6. Ask how many international students the program admitted last year, and how many of those received attestation letters.
7. Confirm in writing whether the institution will issue a 2027 attestation letter, and when it expects its 2027 allocation.
8. Pay tuition only to the institution's own account, never to an agent's account, and keep the receipt.

The agent question

A good agent saves you weeks. A bad one costs you five years, because the misrepresentation finding under section 40 of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act carries a five-year inadmissibility period, and it attaches to you, not to the agent who invented the bank statement. In 2025, 1.8% of refusals cited misrepresentation - small as a share, permanent as a consequence.

Three sentences should end a conversation immediately: "we guarantee the visa", "we will manage the funds showing", and "don't worry about the SOP, we have a template". The first is a lie, the second is fraud, and the third is why thousands of files read identically.

6. The money file: CAD 23,448 is the floor, not the budget

IRCC asks you to prove you can pay tuition, living costs for yourself and any family coming with you, and transportation to and from Canada - without working. For applications submitted on or after 1 September 2026, the living-cost figure for a single applicant outside Quebec is CAD 23,448 a year, up from CAD 22,895 for applications submitted between 1 January 2025 and 31 August 2026.

Family members (including you)	Required per year, from 1 Sep 2026 (CAD)	Up to 31 Aug 2026 (CAD)
1	23,448	22,895
2	29,192	28,502
3	35,888	35,040
4	43,572	42,543
5	49,419	48,252
6	55,736	54,420
7	62,054	60,589
Each additional member	6,318	6,170

Those amounts exclude tuition and travel, which you must also show. Quebec sets its own cost-of-living threshold for the Quebec Acceptance Certificate, so anyone applying to study in Quebec should use Quebec's figures, not this table.

Add tuition, and the number gets uncomfortable

Statistics Canada's preliminary tables for 2026/27 put average international undergraduate tuition at CAD 42,062 a year, against CAD 8,021 for Canadian students. The provincial spread is wide: Ontario CAD 50,088, British Columbia CAD 40,314, Quebec CAD 36,879, Alberta CAD 36,369, Saskatchewan CAD 33,496, Nova Scotia CAD 31,057, Manitoba CAD 23,160, Prince Edward Island CAD 22,067, New Brunswick CAD 20,029, Newfoundland and Labrador CAD 18,911. Average international graduate tuition is CAD 24,693.

So a single student at an average Ontario university is proving roughly CAD 73,500 for the first year - about Rs 45 lakh at CAD 1 = Rs 61 - before airfare, before the CAD 150 study permit fee, before the CAD 85 biometrics fee, before the medical exam. A college diploma in Manitoba might be CAD 15,000 in tuition plus CAD 23,448 living, or about CAD 38,500.

> Province selection is a financial decision before it is a lifestyle decision. The difference between the cheapest and the most expensive province for international undergraduate tuition is more than CAD 30,000 a year.

What counts as proof, and what officers now check

IRCC's published list of acceptable evidence includes a receipt for first-year tuition and housing, a Canadian bank account in your name, a guaranteed investment certificate from a Canadian financial institution, an education loan from a bank, a scholarship or government-funded program, recent pay stubs, a sponsor letter with the sponsor's occupation, relationship to you, number of dependants and amount of support, proof of relationship, and six months of bank statements including the month you apply or the month before, with documentation of the source of the money.

In July 2026, reporting on updated IRCC guidance described officers being directed to examine both the amount and the source of funds, with earlier language limiting extra checks to "very high-risk environments" removed. Unexplained large deposits, inconsistent banking records and weak supporting documents are exactly what gets questioned. That is consistent with the refusal analysis: financial evidence was the leading ground in 47% of the refusal letters studied.

Building a funds file that survives scrutiny

1. Age the money. A lump sum that appears three weeks before you apply, from nowhere, is the most common self-inflicted wound in Indian files. Six months of statements is the benchmark IRCC names.
2. Explain every large credit. A property sale needs the sale deed and the bank credit. A gift needs a gift deed and the donor's source. A loan needs the sanction letter and the disbursement trail.
3. Match names. The account holder, the sponsor and the relationship document must agree exactly, including spelling.
4. Show the full duration. IRCC asks how you will pay for the whole program, not just year one - a scholarship letter covering four years, a parent's employment letter, or a sanctioned loan for the full amount all answer that question.
5. Keep it liquid and convertible. Fixed deposits, mutual funds and property are not the same as money available to you; if you rely on them, show the liquidation path.
6. Mind India's remittance rules. The Liberalised Remittance Scheme allows a resident individual to remit up to USD 250,000 a financial year for permitted purposes including education; check the current RBI limit and your bank's documentation requirements before you plan a transfer.

One more structural point. The requirement is to show funds for the first year, plus a credible plan for the rest. Officers are not required to be satisfied by the minimum. A file showing exactly CAD 23,448 with nothing behind it, for a two-year program, invites the question of year two.

7. The "you will leave Canada" test

Section 216(1) of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Regulations requires an officer to be satisfied that you will leave Canada at the end of your authorised stay. In Indian files this is the decisive test: it contributed to more than 90% of refusals in ApplyBoard's review, appearing through several different coded grounds.

Most applicants answer it by writing "I will return to India to join my father's business" and assuming that settles it. It does not, because it is a claim with no evidence behind it. The officer is asking a narrower question: what specifically is waiting for you in India that is worth more to you than staying.

Evidence that works, in rough order of strength

1. Property or a business interest in your name, with documents - a sale deed, a partnership deed, GST registration, ITR acknowledgements.
2. A job offer or an employer's letter confirming your position is held, with the salary and the date you are expected back. A letter saying "we will consider him" is worth nothing; a letter naming the role is worth a lot.
3. A family business with provable turnover, where your role is described and your qualification is the reason you are needed.
4. A career plan that names Indian employers, roles and salary bands for your field, and explains why the Canadian credential is required for that specific role.
5. Travel history that shows you entered and exited other countries lawfully, with the visas and stamps to prove it.
6. Dependants and family ties in India - carefully, because a spouse and children in India are a tie only if the file also explains how they will be supported while you study.

Dual intent is legal, dishonesty is not

Section 22(2) of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act states that a person who applies for a temporary resident visa and intends to become a permanent resident is not inadmissible on that ground alone. Wanting permanent residence is permitted. What fails is a file that says one thing in the study plan and another everywhere else - a program chosen purely for immigration points, a stated intention to return contradicted by a spouse's work permit application, or a course of study unrelated to any previous qualification or job.

The practical rule: do not write what you think the officer wants to read. Write what is true, and then support it so thoroughly that it reads as a plan rather than a hope. A truthful, coherent file from a 32-year-old with a decade of work experience and a specific reason for a specific program will beat a template every time.

The study plan, paragraph by paragraph

The study plan is not an essay about your feelings about Canada. It is a five-part argument, roughly one page, in this order.

Paragraph	What it must prove	Evidence that must exist in the file
1. Who you are	Your academic and work history is coherent and the program follows from it	Mark sheets, degree certificates, experience letters, a gap explanation if any
2. Why this program	You know what the program teaches, by course name, and why Indian programs do not cover it	Program page, curriculum, correspondence with the institution
3. Why this institution	A specific reason - a lab, a placement record, a faculty specialism, a provincial industry	Not "world-class education"; name the thing

Paragraph	What it must prove	Evidence that must exist in the file
4. How you will pay	The funding story matches the documents exactly	Bank statements, loan sanction, sponsor letter, GIC
5. What happens after	A named role, a named kind of employer, a realistic salary, and the ties that bring you back	Employer letter, business documents, property, family responsibilities

Sentences that hurt you

- "Canada is a peaceful country with a high standard of living." True, irrelevant, and identical in ten thousand files.
- "I will settle in Canada after my studies." Contradicts the temporary intent the permit requires, whatever you actually plan.
- "This program is my dream." Sentiment is not evidence.
- "My uncle will support me." Without his employment letter, relationship proof, dependants and statements, this is an unverified claim.
- "I will decide about my career later." Reads as no plan at all.

8. Language: the score that outlives your admission

There are two language thresholds in your future and they are not the same one. The first is the institution's admission requirement, which varies by program. The second is IRCC's post-graduation work permit requirement, which is fixed in Canadian Language Benchmark terms and applies to you years after you were admitted.

	Admission	Post-graduation work permit
Who sets it	The institution and program	IRCC
Level	Program-specific; typically IELTS 6.0 to 7.0 overall	CLB 7 in all four abilities for bachelor's, master's and doctoral graduates; CLB 5 in all four for other university, college and polytechnic programs
When it matters	Before you are admitted	When you apply for the work permit, up to four years later
What it blocks	Your letter of acceptance	Your work permit - and therefore your route to permanent residence

The asymmetry is the point. A student admitted on IELTS 6.0 to a two-year college diploma, who never retests, may graduate and discover they need CLB 5 in all four abilities for the work permit - usually attainable - while a university graduate needs CLB 7, which is a materially higher bar. Check IRCC's official equivalency chart for your test type rather than trusting a table on a consultancy website; the conversion from IELTS, CELPIP, PTE Core, TEF or TCF to CLB is published and it changes.

Which test to take

Take the test the institution accepts, then plan a second attempt before graduation if your program sits near a threshold. CELPIP-General and IELTS General Training are the two most commonly used for the work permit, and IRCC publishes the tests it accepts. If you are applying to a French-language program, or you are considering French as a permanent residence strategy, TEF or TCF results at NCLC 7 or above are worth far more than any other score you can buy - see the chapter on permanent residence.

> Book the test before you book the flight. Retesting in Canada is possible but expensive, and a work permit application with a missing language result is a refusal, not a request for more information.

9. Applying without getting your file returned

The application itself is the least interesting part of the process and the easiest place to lose a term. A file is returned when a required document is missing, and it is refused when the officer is not satisfied. Those are different failures with different fixes, and the first one is entirely within your control.

The order of operations

1. Get the letter of acceptance from a designated learning institution, and confirm the program is PGWP-eligible with its CIP code in writing.
2. Get the attestation letter, unless you are exempt. For a 2027 intake, confirm the institution can issue one in the 2027 cap year before you pay tuition.
3. Take the immigration medical exam with an IRCC panel physician. India is on IRCC's list of countries where an exam is required for stays over six months, so almost every Indian applicant needs one. Do it before you apply and include the proof - the exam is valid for 12 months from the date it is done, and it must still be valid when you enter Canada.
4. Prepare the funds file. Six months of statements, source of every large credit, sponsor documents if anyone else is paying.
5. Write the study plan, one page, five paragraphs, evidence for each claim.
6. Create an IRCC secure account, complete the application for a study permit made outside Canada (form IMM 1294), and upload the documents.
7. Pay the study permit fee of CAD 150 and, if required, the biometrics fee of CAD 85.
8. Give biometrics at a visa application centre. Biometrics are valid for 10 years, so check whether yours from an earlier application are still live.
9. Wait, and answer any request for additional documents immediately. The processing clock restarts in practice whenever IRCC has to chase you.

What "complete" means

The processing time starts the day IRCC receives a complete application, not the day you press submit. An application missing a document sits outside the queue. This is why two applicants with identical files can wait six weeks and sixteen.

Processing measure	Current figure	Source and date
Study permit from India	8 weeks	IRCC processing times, updated 4 November 2026
Service standard, applications outside Canada	60 days	IRCC 2025-26 Fees Report
Compliance with that service standard	86%	IRCC 2025-26 Fees Report
Doctoral students and their family members	14 days	IRCC International Student Program materials, 2026
Fees	CAD 150 study permit; CAD 85 biometrics; CAD 170 biometrics family maximum	IRCC fee list

Eight weeks is a backward-looking figure: it is how long IRCC took to decide 80% of recently finalised applications from India. About one in five took longer. It is not a maximum and it is not a promise, and IRCC states plainly that calling does not speed anything up.

While you wait

- Do not book a flight until the passport request or the letter of introduction is in your account.
- Do not travel to Canada as a visitor to "wait" for the permit. A study permit cannot be issued to you as a visitor inside Canada on that basis, and the trip costs money you need.
- Use the case-specific enquiry form only when IRCC's own guidance says you may, and only after the published processing time has passed.
- If you are refused, do not immediately reapply. Order the officer's notes first - chapter 13 explains how, and why reapplying blind is the most expensive mistake in this book.

10. Landing, and the first ninety days

Approval is not the permit. What arrives is a letter of introduction, which you present at the port of entry, where the officer issues the actual study permit. That permit is a small piece of paper that governs the next two to four years of your life, and most students read it for the first time in a queue at Toronto Pearson.

At the port of entry

1. Carry the letter of introduction, your passport with the visa, the letter of acceptance, the attestation letter, the tuition receipt, and proof of funds in your hand luggage. Not in the checked bag.
2. Read the permit before you leave the counter: the institution named, the level of study, the expiry date, and whether the work conditions are printed.
3. If the work condition is missing, you cannot get a social insurance number and you cannot work legally. Ask the officer to correct it there, and if that is not possible, apply to amend the permit afterwards - there is no fee to add work conditions you are eligible for.

The rules you will actually live under

Rule	What it means in practice
Work before studies begin	You cannot work until your program starts, even if you have arrived early
Hours during term	Up to 24 hours a week off campus, across as many jobs as you like, if your permit carries the work condition and you hold a SIN
Hours during scheduled breaks	Unlimited off campus during breaks your institution schedules - summer, winter, reading week. If your program has no scheduled break, the 24-hour limit continues
English-language programs	If you are enrolled only in an ESL or FSL program, you cannot work off campus without a work permit
Changing institutions	At the post-secondary level, switching institutions requires a new study permit application - you cannot simply transfer
Authorised leave	If you are on an authorised leave, or between institutions and not studying, you cannot work until you resume
Part-time study	Allowed in your final semester if you do not need a full load, and only if you were full-time until then. Part-time status outside that exception damages your work permit eligibility
Progress	You must make progress towards completing your program. Failure to enrol or make progress is a compliance issue that institutions report on

The 24-hour limit is enforced through your employer's records and your own. Working more is a breach of your permit conditions, can cost you your student status, and can follow you into future applications. It is not worth it: the difference between 24 and 40 hours at minimum wage does not cover what a refused work permit costs.

The practical checklist for week one

- Apply for a social insurance number at Service Canada with your study permit and passport - free, and you cannot be paid without it.
- Open a Canadian bank account and get a credit card designed for students; your Indian credit history does not travel.
- Enrol in health coverage. Some provinces provide it to international students, some require an institutional plan, and several have a waiting period - confirm with your institution's international office in your first week,

not your first illness.

- Register with the institution's international student office and keep your address current in your IRCC account.
- Keep every enrolment letter and transcript. You will need them for the work permit application in two years, and institutions are slow in graduation season.

11. The post-graduation work permit: three gates and one window

The post-graduation work permit is the bridge between study and permanent residence, and it is not automatic. Graduating from a designated learning institution does not make you eligible. You pass three separate sets of requirements, and failing any one of them means no work permit - which, in practice, means leaving.

Gate one: general eligibility

- You completed a program of study at a PGWP-eligible designated learning institution that was at least 8 months long, or 900 hours for Quebec programs.
- You maintained full-time status in Canada in each semester of the program. Part-time study is allowed only in your final semester, if you were full-time before it.
- You applied within 180 days of the confirmation that you completed your program.
- Your study permit was valid at some point during those 180 days.

Gate two: requirements based on your program

Your credential	Language	Field of study
Bachelor's, master's or doctoral degree	CLB 7 in all four abilities	No requirement
Other university program	CLB 7 in all four abilities	Required if you applied for your study permit on or after 1 November 2024
College, polytechnic or non-university program	CLB 5 in all four abilities	Required if you applied for your study permit on or after 1 November 2024
Flight school graduate	No language requirement	No field requirement, but a commercial pilot licence or instructor rating is required

The field-of-study requirement is decided by the six-digit CIP code of your program. IRCC maintains the list of eligible codes, and for 2026 it has frozen the list: nothing will be added or removed during the year. There are currently 1,107 eligible programs, concentrated in health care and social services, education, trades, agriculture, STEM and transport.

If you have to meet the requirement, you must submit proof that you graduated in an eligible field with your application - and because of a system limitation, IRCC asks you to upload that proof in the "Client Information" section of your account. Applicants who meet every substantive requirement and then fail to upload the proof are refused for a filing error.

Gate three: where you were

There are additional requirements connected to physical location - for example, students studying online from outside Canada, or at a campus outside Canada, are treated differently. If any part of your program was delivered outside Canada, check the current instructions before you rely on those months towards a work permit.

How long it lasts

Your program	Work permit you can get
Master's degree of 8 months or more (since 15 February 2024)	3 years, even if the program was shorter than 2 years - this does not apply to certificates or diplomas
Any other program of 8 months but less than 2 years	Up to the length of the program - a 9-month program may produce a 9-month permit
Program of 2 years or more	3 years
More than one program completed	May combine the lengths, if each program was PGWP-eligible and at least 8 months long, and you meet the language requirement for each

Two traps sit inside that table. First, a one-year postgraduate certificate produces a one-year work permit, which is usually too short to accumulate the twelve months of skilled Canadian work experience that Express Entry's Canadian Experience Class requires - you spend the year working and applying at once. Second, the permit is issued only to your passport's expiry date. If your Indian passport expires in 2029 and you are eligible for a three-year permit, you get a permit to 2029 and must renew the passport and apply on paper to extend. Check your passport validity before you apply, and renew it first if you can.

> You cannot get a second post-graduation work permit for a second program if you already had one. The permit is a one-time instrument; plan the whole sequence - program, permit length, work experience, permanent residence - before you choose the program.

12. Permanent residence: the honest arithmetic

Canada admits 380,000 permanent residents a year under the 2027-2029 Immigration Levels Plan. A student who graduates, works and applies is competing inside that number. The route most students take is the Canadian Experience Class inside Express Entry, and the arithmetic of that route should shape your choices in year one.

The Canadian Experience Class, in plain terms

You need skilled work experience in Canada - roughly one year of full-time work, or the part-time equivalent, in the three years before you apply - in an occupation at the skill level IRCC specifies, plus a language result at the level set for your occupation's category, plus admissibility. You create an Express Entry profile, receive a Comprehensive Ranking System score, and wait to be invited.

What the cut-offs actually look like

In 2026, IRCC ran general, program-specific and category-based rounds. The pattern is worth studying, because it tells you where the leverage is.

Round type	Typical 2026 CRS cut-off	What it implies
Canadian Experience Class	507 to 523	One year of Canadian work is necessary but not sufficient
French-language proficiency	382 to 435	The largest single discount available to a student who can reach NCLC 7
Healthcare and social services	467 to 475	Occupation-based rounds beat the general pool by 40 to 50 points
Trade occupations	476 to 477	Trades graduates have a materially easier path
Transport occupations	470	Small rounds, narrow occupation lists
Senior managers with Canadian experience	389 to 429	Relevant to experienced professionals, not new graduates
Physicians with Canadian experience	169 to 223	A special category for practising physicians

The categories in place for 2026 are French-language proficiency; healthcare and social services; STEM; trades; education; transport; physicians with Canadian work experience; senior managers with Canadian work experience; researchers with Canadian work experience; and skilled military recruits. Category rounds do not replace the general pool - they supplement it - and IRCC may skip a category round if enough eligible candidates are already being invited through other rounds.

Three levers that move a score more than another diploma

1. French. NCLC 7 or above in all four abilities opens a category whose cut-offs ran 80 to 130 points below the Canadian Experience Class rounds in 2026. No other investment of study time has that return.
2. Occupation choice. A program that leads to a healthcare, trade or transport occupation puts you in a smaller pool with a lower cut-off. This is a decision you make when you pick the program, not when you apply for permanent residence.
3. The second year of Canadian work. One year of experience makes you eligible; the score continues to rise with more, and the difference between a 480 and a 520 profile is often a second year of work, not another qualification.

Provincial nominee programs are the other door. Provinces nominate candidates for their own labour market needs, and several streams favour graduates of local institutions. The trade-off is that each province runs its own rules, its own occupation lists and its own intake windows, and those change more often than federal rules. Check the province's own immigration website in the year you graduate, not the year you enrol.

The realistic timeline

Stage	Duration	What can go wrong
Study	1 to 4 years	Part-time status, program not PGWP-eligible, institution suspended
Post-graduation work permit	1 to 3 years	Late application, missing language result, ineligible CIP code
Skilled work experience	12 months minimum	Job at the wrong skill level, or an employer who will not document your duties
Express Entry profile and invitation	Weeks to years	Score below the cut-off, category not open to you
Permanent residence application	Typically 6 to 12 months	Incomplete documents, medical or security delays

Add it up honestly: a two-year master's, a three-year work permit, a year of experience and a year of processing is a seven-year plan from the day you apply for the study permit. If that is not the plan you want, the diploma route with a shorter runway is a legitimate choice - but choose it knowingly, not because a brochure said the work permit would sort itself out.

13. Refused: what actually moves the needle

A refusal is not a verdict on your future, but it is a document with a date on it, and the response has a deadline. Read the letter twice before you speak to anyone who charges a fee.

First, order the officer's notes

The refusal letter gives coded grounds; the notes behind it give the reasoning. In Canada, request the Global Case Management System notes through an Access to Information and Privacy request to IRCC - a small fee for most requests, with a statutory response time of about 30 days. What you get is usually one to three paragraphs that tell you precisely which document failed and what the officer concluded from it. Every serious reapplication starts here.

Then choose one of three responses

Response	When it is right	What it costs
Reapply with new evidence	The refusal was about sufficiency - funds, purpose, ties - and you can add documents that did not exist or were not submitted	A new fee and a new wait; the refusal stays on your record but is not itself disqualifying
Judicial review at the Federal Court	The officer made a legal or procedural error, ignored evidence you submitted, or gave reasons that do not follow from the file	Court costs, a lawyer, and a short deadline: 15 days for a matter arising in Canada, 60 days for a matter arising outside Canada
Reconsideration request	There is a clear factual error, such as a document the officer says was missing but was in the file	No court fee, no guarantee of a reply, and it does not extend the judicial review deadline

The judicial review route deserves precision, because it is oversold. The Federal Court does not re-decide your case. It reviews whether the decision was reasonable and the process fair, and if it finds a problem it can only send the file back to be decided again by a different officer. Leave is required first, and there is no appeal from a refusal of leave. If you are considering it, the 60-day clock for an overseas decision is running from the day you were notified - not from the day you finished reading the notes.

The one outcome you cannot fix

A misrepresentation finding under section 40 of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act carries a five-year inadmissibility period, starting from the final determination if the finding was made outside Canada, or from the date a removal order is enforced if it was made in Canada. During that period you cannot apply for permanent residence. It arises from a false document, a concealed fact, or an agent who "arranged" a bank statement. There is no version of this that is worth the risk.

Reapplying well

1. Do not resubmit the same file with a longer cover letter. Officers see the previous decision; new words are not new evidence.
2. Fix the specific ground. If funds were questioned, change the funds structure - a sanctioned loan and a GIC are stronger than a bigger balance with the same unexplained deposits.
3. If purpose was questioned, change the program or add the career evidence that was missing. Sometimes the honest answer is that the program was wrong for you.
4. Address the gap. If you have been refused, say what changed since the last application, in one paragraph, with documents.

5 Keep every version of every file. If you reapply three times, the inconsistencies between versions become the story.

14. The money plan, including the worst case

Nobody in this industry will show you a budget, because the number is the sales objection. Here is the arithmetic anyway, with the verified components marked and the variable ones left for you to fill from your own quotes.

Three profiles, costed

Line item	College diploma, Manitoba	Master's, Ontario	Bachelor's, Newfoundland
Tuition, year one	Program quote (college rates are set per program)	Program quote; provincial average for international graduate study is CAD 24,693	Program quote; provincial average for international undergraduates is CAD 18,911
Living costs, year one	23,448	23,448	23,448
Study permit fee	150	150	150
Biometrics	85	85	85
Medical exam, travel, insurance, test fees	Your quotes	Your quotes	Your quotes
Minimum federal figure before tuition and travel	23,683	23,683	23,683

The comparison that matters is not the tuition line, it is tuition plus living plus the length of the program plus the work permit it produces. A CAD 15,000 diploma that yields a one-year work permit and a CAD 30,000 master's that yields three years are not comparable purchases; the second buys you two extra years of Canadian work experience, which is the actual currency of permanent residence.

The funding stack

1. Family savings, aged in a bank account for at least six months, with the source of any lump sum documented.
2. An education loan sanctioned for the full program cost, not just year one. A sanction letter is strong evidence because it is third-party verified and it answers the "how will you pay for the rest" question.
3. A guaranteed investment certificate from a Canadian financial institution, which converts the living-cost portion into a Canadian-dollar instrument the officer can see.
4. Scholarships, which also help with the purpose argument - a funded student is a credible student.
5. Sponsor support from a parent, documented exactly as IRCC specifies: employment, relationship, dependants, amount, and proof of the relationship.

The worst case, planned in advance

Three bad outcomes are common enough to plan for. The first is a refusal after you have paid a tuition deposit: check the institution's refund policy before you pay, and prefer institutions that refund on refusal. The second is a permit approved for a shorter period than you expected, which usually means your passport expires early. The third is arriving and finding that the program is not what was described, which is why the institution's own program page, not the agent's PDF, should be your source.

And the number nobody wants to write down: if you spend Rs 40 lakh on a two-year program and return to India after it, the credential needs to be worth something in the Indian market. Name the job you expect in

India and the salary band it pays before you enrol. If the answer is "something in management", the plan is not finished.

15. Your calendar, by intake

Applications are not late until the cap runs out or the processing time passes your start date - but both of those happen quietly. Work backwards from the intake, using IRCC's current eight-week figure for India as the planning number and adding four weeks for the unpredictable.

Intake	Apply by	What has to be true by then
January 2027	Already tight - only viable if you hold a letter of acceptance and a 2026 attestation letter now	Attestation letter valid at submission; medical done; funds aged; biometrics given
May 2027	December 2026 to January 2027	Attestation letter issued in the 2027 cap year; confirm your institution has its 2027 allocation
September 2027	February to April 2027	Same, plus time for a refusal and one reapplication before the term starts

The twelve-month version, for a September 2027 start

When	What you do
Now to December 2026	Shortlist six programs by CIP code and PGWP eligibility. Write to each institution asking two questions: can you issue a 2027 attestation letter, and when will you know your allocation. Sit or retake your language test.
January to February 2027	Apply for admission. Start the funds file: statements, loan sanction, sponsor documents. Do not move large sums without a paper trail.
March to April 2027	Receive offers. Compare them on the scorecard in chapter 16, not on the brochure. Pay the deposit only after the attestation letter question is answered in writing.
April to May 2027	Take the medical exam with a panel physician. Collect the attestation letter. Draft the study plan with evidence for every claim.
May to June 2027	Submit the study permit application, pay CAD 150 and CAD 85, give biometrics.
July to August 2027	Wait. Answer any request within 48 hours. If refused, order the notes and decide on reapplication rather than panicking into a second identical file.
August 2027	Receive the letter of introduction. Book travel for after the date your institution allows arrival. Prepare the port-of-entry folder.
September 2027	Land, get the permit, apply for a SIN, enrol in health cover, register with the international office.

One honest note about timing: because the 2027 cap and provincial allocations were not published as of this writing, a September 2027 applicant is planning against a rule set that will be confirmed in the months before they apply. That is not a reason to wait. It is a reason to keep every institutional commitment in writing, and to avoid any payment that is not refundable on refusal.

16. Five files, five decisions

The rules are abstract until they land on a person. These five profiles are composites built from the rules in this book, not real applicants. Each one shows a single decision that changes the outcome, and the arithmetic behind it.

Profile 1: the married applicant who chose a diploma

Twenty-eight, married, a commerce graduate with four years in a family distribution business, budget about Rs 30 lakh. The agent recommended a two-year postgraduate diploma in supply chain management at a college in Ontario, because it was the cheapest route to a three-year work permit.

What the recommendation missed: since 21 January 2025 the spouse of a college student is not eligible for an open work permit. The couple had planned for the spouse to work and contribute roughly CAD 2,500 a month towards living costs. On the diploma route, that income does not exist, and the funds requirement is still calculated for one person - the spouse can come as a visitor, not a worker, and cannot support the household legally.

The alternative: a master's program of 16 months or longer at a public institution. Higher tuition, but no attestation letter needed from January 2026, three-year work permit from a program of 8 months or more, and a spouse who can work. For this couple, the master's was the cheaper option once the lost spousal income was counted - and it was the only option that matched the plan they had already made.

Profile 2: the strong student refused on funds

Twenty-three, first-class engineering degree, IELTS 7.5, admitted to a master's program in Alberta, funds arranged by an uncle who transferred CAD 30,000 into the applicant's account six weeks before submission. Refused. The coded ground cited financial insufficiency and doubts about the applicant's financial status.

The file had the money and none of the explanation. There was no sponsor letter stating the uncle's occupation, his relationship to the applicant, his number of dependants or the amount of support. There was no evidence of the source of the CAD 30,000. The six-month statement requirement was met on paper only, because the account had existed for eight weeks.

The fix was not a bigger number. It was a gift deed, the uncle's employment letter and three months of his pay slips, his bank statement showing the transfer leaving his account, a relationship document, and a written explanation of why the family had pooled funds. Same student, same program, same money - approved on reapplication.

Profile 3: the one-year certificate and the one-year permit

Twenty-six, three years in IT support, wanted the fastest route to Canadian work experience. Enrolled in a one-year graduate certificate in project management at a college, on the understanding that the work permit would be three years.

The rule: a program of 8 months but less than 2 years produces a work permit of up to the same length as the program. The three-year permit applies to programs of two years or more, and to master's degrees of 8 months or more since February 2024 - not to certificates. So the graduate got a one-year permit, which is just long enough to accumulate the twelve months of skilled work needed for the Canadian Experience Class, with no margin for a job search, a layoff or a slow employer.

Two better versions existed: a two-year program at the same college, or a master's. The lesson is not that certificates are bad. It is that the permit length is a fact you can look up before you pay the deposit, and almost nobody does.

Profile 4: the file that arrived after the cap ran out

Twenty, second-year undergraduate in India, applying for a bachelor's program in Ontario with a letter of acceptance and a deposit paid. The application was returned unprocessed, with the fee refunded, because the provincial allocation for that year had been exhausted.

Returned is not refused, and the applicant did nothing wrong. But the deposit was non-refundable except on refusal, so the money was gone, and the intake was missed. The institution had known its allocation was close to exhausted when it took the deposit. The question that would have prevented it - "how much of your allocation remains, and will you confirm in writing that you can issue an attestation letter" - costs nothing to ask.

Profile 5: the refusal that was really about intent

Thirty-one, eight years in banking, admitted to a one-year business program with no obvious connection to a banking career. The study plan said Canada offered a better quality of life and that the applicant hoped to build a future there. Funds were strong. Refused under the ground that the officer was not satisfied the applicant would leave Canada at the end of the authorised stay.

Everything the officer needed was available and none of it was in the file: a promotion letter showing the role waiting in India, the specific regulatory skills the program taught that Indian banking roles now require, the family property, and the fact that the applicant's parents depended on him. The word "future" in the study plan did more damage than any missing document.

> In all five profiles the money was similar. What differed was whether the applicant had checked one rule before spending it.

17. Questions people actually ask

These are the questions that come up in every intake cycle, answered against the rules as published on 10 November 2026. Where the answer depends on your circumstances, it says so.

Do I need a provincial attestation letter for a master's?

Not if the master's or doctoral program is at a public designated learning institution and you are applying from 1 January 2026 onwards. A graduate certificate or postgraduate diploma is not a master's degree and still needs one. A master's at a private institution needs one.

Can my spouse work in Canada while I study?

Only if you hold a valid study permit and are enrolled in a master's program of 16 months or longer, a doctoral program, or one of the listed professional degree programs such as engineering, nursing, education, law, medicine, dentistry, pharmacy, optometry or veterinary medicine. Spouses of college diploma students, undergraduates and most short master's programs are not eligible for an open work permit. If a spouse already holds one under the previous rules, it remains valid until it expires.

How much money do I need to show?

For an application submitted on or after 1 September 2026, CAD 23,448 for a single applicant outside Quebec, plus tuition and return travel, plus a credible plan for the rest of the program. The figure rises with family size: CAD 29,192 for two, CAD 35,888 for three, CAD 43,572 for four. Quebec sets its own amount for the Quebec Acceptance Certificate.

Is it true that the Student Direct Stream is closed?

Yes. IRCC discontinued the Student Direct Stream, and its own materials describe the change as putting all applicants on an equal footing regardless of country of origin. There is no fast lane for Indian applicants. Plan for the regular stream processing time, currently eight weeks from India.

How long will my work permit be after graduation?

Three years if your program was two years or more, or if it was a master's degree of 8 months or more. Up to the length of the program if it was between 8 months and two years. Multiple eligible programs of 8 months or more each can be combined. The permit is also limited by your passport's expiry date, so renew your passport first if you can.

Does my program need to be on a list for the work permit?

It depends on your credential. Degree holders - bachelor's, master's, doctoral - have no field-of-study requirement. If you are in a college, polytechnic or other non-degree program and you applied for your study permit on or after 1 November 2024, your program's six-digit CIP code must be on IRCC's eligible list. The list is frozen for 2026 at 1,107 programs.

Can I change colleges after I arrive?

At the post-secondary level, changing institutions requires a new study permit application. You cannot simply transfer, and you cannot work while you are between institutions and not studying. If you are considering a change, speak to your institution's international office before you stop attending - an unauthorised gap damages both your status and your work permit eligibility.

How many hours can I work while studying?

Up to 24 hours a week off campus during term, unlimited hours during scheduled breaks such as summer, winter and reading week, provided your permit carries the work condition and you have a social insurance number. You cannot work before your program starts, and students enrolled only in English or French language programs cannot work off campus without a work permit.

Will a refusal ruin my chances of a visa later?

A refusal for insufficient evidence is not a ban, and many approved applicants were refused once. What does lasting damage is a misrepresentation finding under section 40 of the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act, which carries five years of inadmissibility, or a pattern of inconsistent files. Order the officer's notes, fix the specific ground, and reapply with new evidence rather than new wording.

Should I apply for permanent residence through Express Entry or a provincial program?

Most students use the Canadian Experience Class inside Express Entry after a year of skilled Canadian work. Provincial nominee programs are a second route that favours graduates of local institutions, but each province runs its own occupation lists and intake windows. Check both in the year you graduate; the rules that applied when you enrolled may not be the rules you face.

Is it worth learning French?

If you can reach NCLC 7 in all four abilities, it is the largest single advantage available. In 2026 the French-language proficiency category ran at cut-offs between 382 and 435, against 507 to 523 for Canadian Experience Class rounds. That is the difference between being invited and waiting years. It is also a decision to start in your first year in Canada, not your last.

18. Worksheets

Print these six pages, or copy them into a notebook. The value is in writing answers down and looking at them, not in reading them.

Worksheet 1: Program scorecard

Score each program from 1 to 5 on each line. Anything scoring 1 on the first four lines should be dropped regardless of total.

Criterion	Why it decides the outcome	Program A	Program B	Program C
PGWP-eligible with CIP code confirmed in writing	No code, no work permit			
Attestation letter available for your cap year	No letter, no application			
Spouse open work permit eligible	Master's of 16 months or more, doctorate, or listed professional degree			
Total cost for the full program	Tuition plus living for every year, not year one			
Credential value in the Indian market	The outcome if you return			
Institution compliance record	A suspension returns your application			
Co-op, internship or placement record	Canadian experience before graduation			
Province: permanent residence options for graduates	Provincial nominee streams differ			
Refund policy on refusal	Protects your deposit			
Language threshold to graduate and to get the permit	CLB 7 for degrees, CLB 5 for college			

Worksheet 2: Funds worksheet

Line	Amount (CAD)	Document that proves it	Done
Tuition, year one		Institution receipt or invoice	
Living costs, applicant	23,448	Bank statements, GIC, loan	
Living costs, each accompanying family member	See chapter 6 table	Same	
Return travel for applicant and family		Itinerary or funds	
Proof of funds for the rest of the program		Loan sanction, sponsor letter, scholarship	
Source of every deposit above the monthly pattern		Sale deed, gift deed, maturity advice, salary slips	
Total available funds			
Gap to close			

Worksheet 3: Document checklist

Document	Who issues it	Validity or note	Done
Passport	Passport Seva	Must outlast the permit you want; renew early if not	
Letter of acceptance	Institution	Verified by IRCC with the institution	
Provincial or territorial attestation letter	Province, via institution	Expires 31 December if undated	
Immigration medical exam proof	IRCC panel physician	Valid 12 months; must be valid on arrival	
Biometrics	Visa application centre	Valid 10 years	
Academic transcripts and certificates	Board or university	Include the gap explanation if any	
Language test result	Test provider	Check CLB equivalency for the permit you will need later	
Proof of funds	Bank, lender, sponsor	Six months of statements	
Sponsor documents	Employer and sponsor	Occupation, relationship, dependants, amount, relationship proof	
Study plan	You	One page, five paragraphs, evidence for each	
Police clearance certificate	Passport office or district police	Only if IRCC requests it, or if you declared a criminal record	

Worksheet 4: Refusal diagnosis

Question	Your answer
Which coded ground or grounds did the letter cite?	
What does the officer's note say the problem was, in their words?	
Was the problem a missing document, a weak document, or a contradiction?	
Did the file contain evidence the officer appears not to have considered?	
What new evidence exists today that did not exist before?	
Is the same program still the right program?	
Reapply, request reconsideration, or judicial review - and by what date?	

Worksheet 5: Timeline planner

Milestone	Target date	Owner	Status
Language test booked and taken			
Programs shortlisted with CIP codes verified			
Admission applications submitted			
Attestation letter question answered in writing			

Milestone	Target date	Owner	Status
Funds aged six months			
Medical exam completed			
Study permit submitted			
Biometrics given			
Decision received			
Travel booked			

Worksheet 6: Ten questions for any agent or consultant

1. Are you a regulated consultant, and what is your registration number? Verify it with the regulator named for Canadian immigration consultants.
2. Will you put in writing that you will not submit any document that I have not personally verified?
3. Which specific programs are you recommending, and what are their six-digit CIP codes?
4. Can you confirm in writing that each recommended institution can issue an attestation letter for my cap year?
5. What is your fee, in total, and what does it exclude?
6. Will you share the GCMS notes if I am refused?
7. Who writes the study plan, and will I see it before it is submitted?
8. What happens to my deposit if I am refused?
9. Will you give me the IRCC portal login in my own name?
10. If you are wrong about eligibility, what is your liability?

19. Sources, and how to check anything in this book

Every figure in this book was taken from the following sources on 10 November 2026. Where a number will change - processing times weekly, living-cost thresholds annually, cap allocations yearly - the source is given so you can check the current value.

Primary sources

- IRCC, 2026 provincial and territorial allocations under the international student cap, 25 November 2025 - cap, permit targets, provincial allocations, attestation letter exemptions.
- Canada Gazette, Part 1, Volume 159, Number 51, 20 December 2025 - ministerial instructions on attestation letters, the 309,670 application maximum, expiry and reuse rules.
- IRCC, Supplementary Information for the 2027-2029 Immigration Levels Plan, 5 November 2026 - 370,000 temporary resident arrivals a year, 150,000 students, 380,000 permanent residents.
- IRCC, Study permit: Who can apply, and Proof of financial support - eligibility, documents, and the living-cost table effective 1 September 2026.
- IRCC, Work off campus as an international student - 24-hour limit, scheduled breaks, SIN conditions.
- IRCC, Help your spouse or common-law partner work in Canada - open work permit eligibility since 21 January 2025.
- IRCC, Post-graduation work permit: About, Who can apply, and Field of study requirement - language thresholds, field-of-study list, program length rules.
- IRCC, Express Entry: Category-based selection - the ten 2026 categories and their eligibility rules.
- IRCC, CIMM committee briefing, International Students, 20 April 2026 - refusal rate of 59% for 2025 against 52% for 2024, and misrepresentation rates.
- IRCC, 2025-2026 Fees Report and the fee list - CAD 150 study permit, CAD 85 biometrics, service standards of 60 days outside Canada and 86% compliance.
- IRCC, Check current processing times - study permit from India, 8 weeks, updated 4 November 2026.
- IRCC, Find out if you need a medical exam for your temporary resident application - India listed as requiring an exam, medical office New Delhi.
- IRCC, How to get a police certificate, India - Police Clearance Certificate; character certificates not accepted.
- Statistics Canada, Table 37-10-0045-01, Tuition fees by level of study, 2026/27, released 16 September 2026 - CAD 42,062 international undergraduate average, CAD 24,693 international graduate average.
- Province of British Columbia, Post-Secondary International Education (Designated Institutions) Act - designation certificates required from 1 September 2026.
- Federal Court of Canada, How to file an application for leave and for judicial review (immigration) - 15 days in Canada, 60 days outside Canada.
- Immigration and Refugee Protection Act, section 40 - misrepresentation and the five-year inadmissibility period; section 22(2) - dual intent.

Secondary sources used for refusal analysis

- Reuters, 3 November 2025 - about 74% of Indian applications to Canadian post-secondary institutions refused in August 2025, against about 32% in August 2023.
- ApplyBoard, Common student visa refusal reasons, 12 August 2026 - Indian approval rate of 30% for 2025 and 41% for January to April 2026; the "will not leave Canada" ground in over 90% of Indian refusals.

- Economic Times, 31 July 2026 - updated IRCC guidance on source and stability of funds, and the finding that inadequate proof of finances was the leading refusal reason in 47% of 1,370 refusal letters.
- CIC News, 15 January 2026 - IRCC freeze on the post-graduation work permit field-of-study list for 2026, and 1,107 eligible programs.

How to check a number before you rely on it

1. If it is a fee, it is on IRCC's fee list, and fees adjust on 1 December each year.
2. If it is a funds threshold, it is on the proof of financial support page, and it changes on 1 September each year.
3. If it is a processing time, it is on the check processing times tool, and it changes weekly.
4. If it is a cap or allocation, it is a news notice on canada.ca, published once a year, usually in November.
5. If it is a rule, it is in the Immigration and Refugee Protection Act or Regulations, or in ministerial instructions published in the Canada Gazette.

> This edition reflects the rules as published on 10 November 2026. IRCC publishes new instructions most months. Before you submit, spend twenty minutes on canada.ca confirming the five numbers your file depends on.